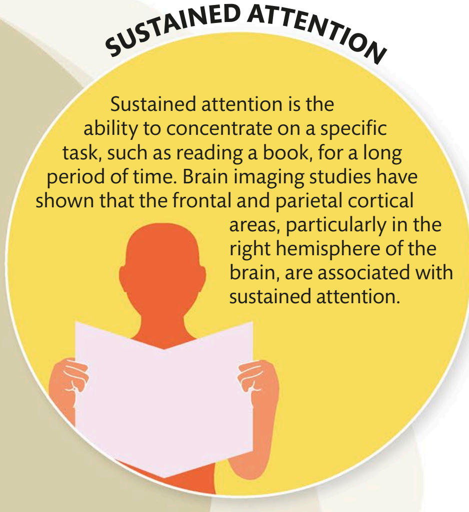
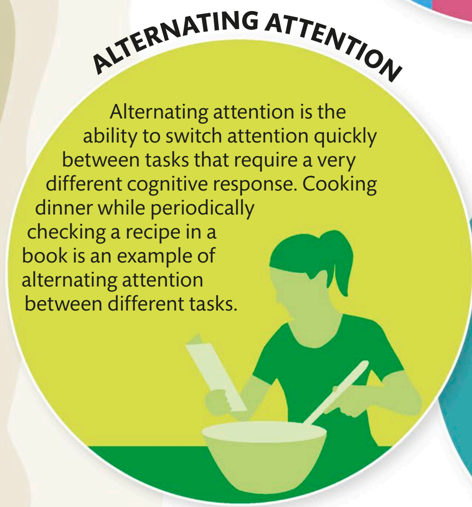
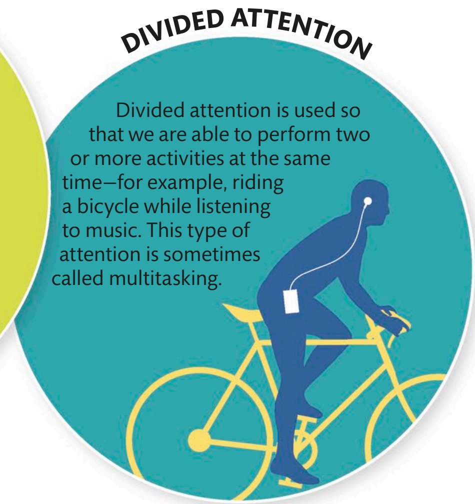


Types of attention

There are various types of attention, and the sort of attention that is required depends on the circumstances that we are in. Both sustained and selective attention are used when we need to focus fully on one stimulus. Alternating and divided attention are used when there are multiple inputs that we need to focus on at the same time. Attention is not an unlimited resource and the process of focusing our attention on something can be tiring, as it needs a significant amount of energy.





Distractions

The brain is not able to focus our attention constantly. Instead, it cycles rapidly between two different states: attention and distraction. During periods of distraction, the brain scans the environment to check that there is nothing more important to which it should be paying attention. This cycle is thought to give an evolutionary advantage to humans, allowing us to respond quickly to either new opportunities or threats.

Looking for trouble
Even when we think we are focused on a task, our brain is checking the environment so that attention can be diverted if necessary.